world to the verge of nuclear war, and terribly frightening the organizer of so dangerous a venture himself. Having no other recourse, we were forced to accept all the demands and conditions dictated by the USA, including the shameful inspection of our ships by the Americans. At the demand of the USA, the missiles, as well as most of the armed forces, were withdrawn from Cuba.… But, as you know, Comrade Khrushchev also represents the defeat in the Caribbean crisis as a victory."[12]

Poliansky went on to argue that the Cuban venture had diminished the standing and international reputation of the party, the Soviet state, and the armed forces, as well as Soviet-Cuban relations. But if the international prestige of the party and state and the worsening of Cuban-Soviet relations were things that only people at the very top of the Soviet hierarchy knew and cared about, the humiliation of the military was an experience shared by thousands of Soviet officers and soldiers on their way back across the Atlantic to their home bases.

Soviet ships leaving Cuba with missiles, equipment, and servicemen were chased by American airplanes and had to open their holds to show the missiles that they had so carefully hidden on the way to Cuba. It was the retreat of a defeated army that many believed to have been betrayed by its leader.

"Neither the Russian nor the Soviet army had ever suffered such humiliation as to allow the adversary to inspect weapons transports," said Khrushchev's right-hand man at the time of the crisis, Marshal Rodion Malinovsky, addressing his general staff in October 1964 on the occasion of Khrushchev's ouster. Anastas Mikoyan considered Malinovsky his nemesis, a hawk who had helped Khrushchev launch the Cuban debacle. But in addressing his top commanders, Malinovsky knew that he was expressing the feelings of many if not most of them.[13]

Nikita Khrushchev had achieved his goal: he saved Cuba from a probable American invasion, kept it communist, and prevented it from defecting to the Chinese camp. He did not get to keep his rockets in Cuba to make up for American superiority in long-range missiles, but he got Kennedy to remove his own medium-range missiles from Turkey. Except in his own statements and pronouncements, Khrushchev never got credit for what he had achieved. The price that everyone—Americans, Cubans, and